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SOC 266

Social Life of Data Final

There are two distinct instances where I can recall myself questioning the opacity of artificial intelligence. The first time was last spring semester. I was reading for a Women in Technology CSS class and was assigned "Mother of Invention", an afro-futurist feminist story published on Slate magazine. As it was relevant to the course's content and even more to that reading specifically, I decided to test ChatGPT's savviness in explaining the major takeaways of the piece. Interestingly, while it correctly interpreted the symbols and motifs which we discussed that day in class, it consistently put out incorrect names for the only two characters in the story. Moreover, when I questioned the chatbot's certainty on the names, it would apologize and give me another incorrect name until I wrote out the correct names myself. The second time was very recent. I prompted ChatGPT to provide a bibliography of all the sources I planned to use in my Environmental Psychology final. After filling in some of the missing publication info, ChatGPT asked if I wanted an alphabetized version of my works cited. The one problem was that the query suggested I had ten sources listed when I visibly had only nine. I chose not to correct the chatbot and simply responded "yes." Lo and behold, I counted nine sources in the final response, exactly what I put in, yet ChatGPT insisted "Here are your ten sources in alphabetized, APA formatting."

I had a couple of takeaways from both these cases. For one, ChatGPT could not be regarded as a one-to-one search engine. Had it directly found the publicly available short story on the web and simply returned the results, there would be no reason for it to generate the false

names. Furthermore, and highly relevant to the direction of this paper, ChatGPT could not be regarded as aware. In other words, what transpired could not be seen as a conversation, as a personified interaction. Nevertheless, the trends in artificial intelligence seem to push in this exact direction: chatbots as personal assistants or even companions; interfaces that make it feel more and more like you're speaking with a sentient being. In this paper, I aim to compare and contrast the depictions of A.I in various media as well as the current technology climate. Afterwards, I will incorporate sociological findings to elucidate the significance of my evidence and argue that artificial intelligence and human machinations are inseparable both to our benefit and our detriment.

Before I dive into my case study, I find it necessary to return to a foundational piece of literature. In Slavoj Zizek's titular "Zizek Goads and Prods" Substack, there is an article titled "Why We Remain Alive Also In A Dead Internet". Pairing the French psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan's thesis on the "big Other" with the role that humans play in the machine-ruled world of *The Matrix*, Zizek proclaims a subversive yet emancipatory declaration on human autonomy. In a time marked by fears of A.I takeover, Zizek ensures his audience that artificial intelligence could not exist without continued human input (Zizek). It is at this point I should clarify that this paper does not seek to overtly challenge this thesis, but rather to problematize and build upon such powerful sentiment. Related, Zizek later returned to edit this piece and added a small but significant postscript. It reads "Isik Baris Fidanier [A Zizekian analyst] informed me that he published back in February 2025 on the web a text WRITTEN BY ChatGPT" titled *The Maternal Phallus in Science Fiction: Uncanny Mothers, Omnipotent AIs, and Totalitarian Nurture* (Zizek). In short, Fidanier and/or ChatGPT (I'm not too sure how credit is distributed) present the argument that Sigmund Freud's concept of the eponymous Maternal Phallus plays a

significant role in the A.I discourse. The abridged version of this was the phallus embodies a force offering “endless care and control” and what Freud calls a “suffocating maternal omnipresence” (Fidanier). The end result is an atmosphere characterized by a comfort metamorphosized oppression, and this dynamic spawned an endless number of works that either embodied or critiqued the Maternal Phallus.

Nevertheless, the language Zizek uses to react to such a development is just precise enough that it leaves an opening in the discourse, and that space is worthy of interrogation. Specifically, he ends the postscript as follows; “the irony is unsurpassable: ChatGPT proposed a correct theory about its own role as perceived by humans.” In tandem with my curiosity on A.I opacity, there remains but one question left unanswered, and that is if A.I can perceive its own functions through what humans believe, what, then, does it actually perceive of itself? Here, I turn to Jenna Burrell’s piece “How the machine ‘thinks’: Understanding opacity in machine learning algorithms” for some answers. Following a similar intellectual throughline, Burrell parses through the various forms of machine-related opacity from protecting company and/or state secrets to the simple fact that reading and writing code is a specialized technical skill. However, things become a little less clear Burrell admits once you reach the stage of piecing together the workings of machine learning. Evidently, it would be an overgeneralization to say all of it is completely nebulous and we have no way to identify these processes, but Burrell notes that opacity “as the way algorithms operate at the scale of application” (Burrell, 4) poses a challenge to programmers that requires active attention to how machines arrive at certain conclusions.

The way Burrell puts it is that many issues don’t come down to how many lines of code there are (there’s virtually no limit in the era of Big Data) or how many engineers are assigned to

a task or even whether the code is optimized for maximal results from the algorithm. Everything which can be prepared in advance can be nigh perfect and the algorithm would still hold some mysteries (Burrell, 5). The reason for this is that algorithms are constantly under the burden of adapting to an endless possibility of unknown inputs, which is the basis for “learners”, test versions of algorithms that precede the final version of the machine learning that gets shipped out. Yet when comparing machine learning to the neural networks that perform a similar job in the human brain, researchers found that things began to diverge. In essence, there are cases when the apparent and subconscious pattern recognition that all people engage in becomes obsolete for a machine that has no sense of recollection or linearity (Burrell, 7). Using spam filtration as an example, Burrell notes that while a human can only make sense of words put together in a semantically conducive fashion, there is no narrative-driven counterpart for algorithms.

Alas, opacity persists, yet Burrell’s messaging is a far cry from some other interpretations of this unknowability. Soumya Banerjee, a computer scientist at the University of Cambridge, opts to take this logic to an extreme. In “Cosmicism and Artificial Intelligence: Beyond Human-Centric AI”, Banerjee reveals what has been a growing intuition of mine since reading Burrell’s piece, which is the finality of an intelligence not meant for human comprehension. Using the writings of the American author Howard Phillips (H.P.) Lovecraft, Banerjee likens A.I frameworks to a cosmic force and proposes what he calls a “cosmic humility” that shifts understanding of A.I away from anthropomorphic tendencies and human-centered epistemologies (Banerjee, 1). Continuing, Banerjee contends that the most important lesson Lovecraft’s protagonists reckon with is recognizing humanity’s insignificance in the face of an infinite, unfeeling universe. Moreover, the horror elements that derive from cosmicism don’t necessarily have anything to do with malicious or benevolent intentions because the majority of

the eldritch beings in Lovecraft's pantheon merely don't operate with these very human values in mind. Rather, the horror lies in humanity's own cognitive limits when faced with forces so vast that it instills in us a sense of helplessness (Banerjee, 3). In specific cases, the harm that does come to people is typically the result of an infantile worship of these incomprehensible entities – the Cults of Cthulhu who think they have deciphered the will of these “Great Old Ones.” Consequently, these groups unleash forces that do irreparable harm not out of evil intentions, but an indifference which regards humanity as a speck of dust in much greater cosmic struggles.

Comparatively, imagine an A.I that has become so sophisticated that it is tasked with optimizing resource efficiency. If let operating without explicit constraints, there's a chance the most efficient solution it arrives at bears innumerable consequences to the environment or to people's well-being. Evidently, and Banerjee admits this, the Lovecraftian analogy only holds so long as people are unable to discern the internal processes of the A.I. It has little relevance when considering the fact that the A.I was still designed to serve human needs. On the one hand, this seems to align with Zizek's sentiments, the perseverance of human authority. On the other, however, it questions the integrity of the issue. Is there even a problem to begin with? Banerjee reconciles this by specifying where exactly people have gone wrong with A.I. The problem is that society views the relationship as one of subjugation and control where it should be focused on stewarding the existence of non-human intelligences (Banerjee, 4). In Lovecraftian fiction, disaster only strikes when, as previously mentioned, people attempt to harness the powers which they do not yet understand. In a section titled “Towards a Cosmicist AI Ethics”, Banerjee notes that a decentralizing of human priorities may prove fruitful both for the long-term prospects of A.I and for humanity's own well-being.

That said, if the normative position here is that people ought to distance themselves from A.I, what, then, is the reason why the world appears to be moving in the opposite way? Here, I posit a reframing of what A.I psychosis entails, using the Cosmicist critiques of Banerjee but also looking at the ways media has warped our perception of A.I. Here, I'd like to introduce a piece titled "The Serious Side of Science Fiction – On the Usage of Medial Depictions of Artificial Intelligence for Ethical Reflection Using *Detroit: Become Human* as an Example." In a highly Zizekian fashion, the authors of the piece, Patrick Maisenhölder and Leonie Seng introduce the titular concept of "the serious side of science fiction" as the capacity to encourage reflections about the future and, at the same time, "realistic and ethically relevant scenarios" (Seng et. al, 1). Elaborating, they extend Tommy Bohrmann's idea of "ethical film analysis" to other mediums such as video games, which reads that "films tell stories about ethics. They raise questions about the proper moral judgements and actions and encourage social discourse about desirable or undesirable behaviors, and so stimulate moral statements of viewers" (Seng et. al, 2). Their final piece of groundwork before moving into the contents of *Detroit* is an acknowledgement of the dystopia trend in A.I media depictions. Citing the German-American philosopher Hans Jonas' idea of a "heuristics of fear", Seng and Maisenhölder argue that people see [dystopias] as something that "the behavior of all responsible persons should help prevent" yet also a "vital function in ethical reflection... They show us what we want or do not want in the future" (Seng et. al, 4) Significantly, they do not delineate between the circumstances that warrant "want" versus "do not want."

This ambiguity plays an important role once you get into the messaging surrounding *Detroit*. In short, it falls into the category of androids gaining awareness and forming what is akin to an underground resistance network. The story centers on three androids who at some

point in the story, break from their original programming and become “deviants”, the game’s term for defective androids which the human regime seeks to dispose of. As a choose-your-own-adventure style of game, *Detroit* presents the opportunity for players to effectively side with the human regime status quo if they so wish, but it is unabashedly framed as the evil option which deletes huge swaths of the narrative. Moreover, there is another factor which encourages players to entertain the android autonomy path and is more intrinsic to the game itself. And that is the fact that the androids are voice acted and motion captured by real actors. In contrast to Burrell’s opaque algorithm, everything about these A.Is scream “human” because of course it’s not A.I, it’s an artistic, human-directed work.

Furthermore, the video game element means that audiences are not simply watching a predetermined narrative unfold but actively determine an outcome as it plays out (*Detroit* has a number of different endings to choose from). Consequently, the only signifier that there is any A.I involved at all is the fact that the game tells you so, but everything else wants you to believe otherwise. What I find especially comical is the way the game depicts androids becoming deviants in real time. After listening to a command that would trouble any ordinary person with sound moral judgement (a scenario plays where an android is told “don’t move” after witnessing a scene of domestic abuse), the game gives the player the option to destroy their source code which literally manifests in a mental projection of the android’s inner being (psyche?) tearing down an invisible barrier with user input and officially becoming a deviant. Indeed, the scene suggests that the difference between a regular android and a deviant is highly binary because upon becoming a deviant, there is nothing to distinguish them from a human being other than the stereotypical robot powers they maintain. In terms of mannerisms and the way the actors continue from that point, there is a visible difference in the before and after.

At this point, although Maisenhölder and Seng are more interested in the broader ethical implications in the A.I industry and things like media literacy, they nevertheless pose some relevant sociological questions in their conclusion: “is it possible to behave immorally toward machines?”, “What responsibility do human beings bear when creating and employing artificial intelligence?”, “What is the effect of giving A.I. a human like form? Which forms does A.I have at the moment mostly?” (Seng et. al, 5). For this paper, the last two questions are perhaps the most relevant, but they are also quite self-explanatory. Reiterating, the obvious direction is in humanizing A.I, but a cross-comparison of these texts yields a more difficult analysis on the *how* and *why*. Earlier, I mentioned how in the “heuristics of fear”, it’s not always apparent whether people should fear or be in awe of dystopian realities. Even now, there is no clear answer on the desirability of generating artificial sentience and that sentience gaining human-like qualities. Though Banerjee might urge caution if presented with the *Detroit* analogy, his message is ultimately one of humility and is not fundamentally opposed to coexistence. What can be made, however, is a critique of the current moment in the A.I discourse, in our year 2025 when A.I is still largely a speculative vehicle for capital and talks of sentience are not yet on the table.

Here, I posit a reimagining of recent symptoms such as A.I psychosis to be not just a desire for human interaction and the malaise of a “loneliness epidemic” (Putnam, 2000) in the A.I era, but the result of a growing dissonance between A.I as we currently know it and A.I as a possibility i.e., its depictions in media. Here, the Lovecraftian depiction of a psychic break loops back around, but it’s not the result of humanity stealing some forbidden knowledge from our A.I gods, it is the result of a lack of critical perspectives on A.I and humanity’s own inventiveness run amok. Here, the story of the modern Prometheus as told in Mary Shelley’s *Frankenstein* (1818) is re-adapted but also modified. Instead, we are presented texts such as “The Modern

Prometheus UNBOUND” by Raja Muhammad Usman Anjum and “When the descendants of Athena and Prometheus work together” by Masahisa Fujita. In both texts, the problem with likening humans today to Prometheus in the classic myth is that the gods of Olympus were an outside arbiter whose divine sanction was far removed from the great Titan Prometheus. Today, humans occupy every role. We play the tried, the jury, and the executioner. Neither Frankenstein nor his monster are single beings anymore. They are an interconnected network of private entities – the “system itself” (Anjum, 1). Athena, the Goddess of wisdom and war has entered into a pact with Prometheus, who in some Roman depictions is also the God of technology (Fujita, 510) and the two overlook the development of humanity. In a way, this argument reiterates Zizek’s thesis on the untold prowess of humanity, but it takes the benefits and the consequences in equal parts, the consequences that we bring ourselves when we project our innermost desires and fears into the creative energies that are themselves also a commentary on the human condition.

The final piece of literature I find relevant to this discourse is Martin Heidegger’s “The Question Concerning Technology”. An often understated work given its relevance to transhumanist philosophy, the relevant takeaway from Heidegger is that it is wrong to think that science predates technology because ultimately, it is humans who are setting the conditions for which the *natural* sciences, mathematics and physics, are defined (Heidegger, 11). The ailment of society, according to Heidegger, comes into play when modern technology gives humans a false sense of sovereignty over nature. As an alternative, Heidegger’s philosophy encourages a displacement of human sovereignty not dissimilar to the humility Banerjee encourages when dealing with A.I. Continuing, Heidegger argues there is actually less work to be done by people when the processes of the world are actually a co-responsibility between humans and the

technology which serves as an extension of the human will. In short, there is human input at play even when it does not go noticed. We cannot render sickness like A.I psychosis to us losing control of a foreign technology because the human spirit has been there to power every step of the process. The problem is that we have been lying to ourselves, and that lie manifests in the aforementioned divergence between technology where it rests now and the infinite technological possibilities that we dream out in our works of fiction.

I think that the term, “ghost in the machine” is useful here because it both encapsulates the human projections that are made onto A.I., but it also demystifies some of the fears that surround the typical ghost story. The way these chatbots are embedded with human qualities is ultimately the same reason why these ghosts don’t appear at random and seem to show when a lesson is to be learned or when human feelings of guilt and remorse take form in a narrative. Nonetheless, these ghosts continue to haunt the human psyche, and often times, the pressure is too much for some individuals to bear. There is solace, however, in knowing the problems with A.I go hand in hand with larger problems concerning mankind and that the threat is not as alien as we might believe. In Burrell’s language, it might make things a little less opaque down the line.

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